

A Talk Is an Evaluation Story

DATA 443/643 · Week 14, note 14.3

Week 14

American University

Ahmad Mousavi

Talk craft from Peyton Jones; numbers from this course. Original slides.

Lecture plan

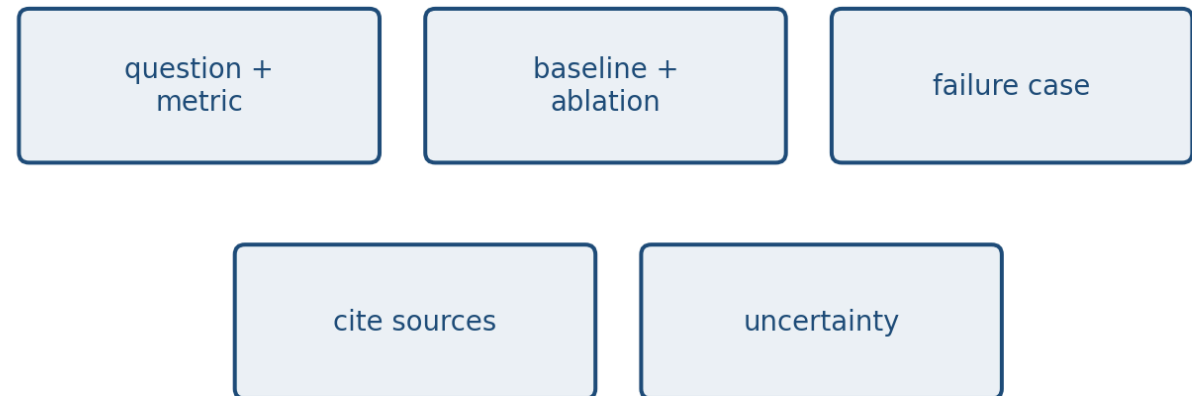
- 1 A metric that could change your mind
- 2 Baseline, split, n, seeds
- 3 +2 pp vs 4 pp of seed noise
- 4 One failure case with ids

Key goal: question, table, ablation, failure. Not a notebook tour.

Write a falsifiable sentence

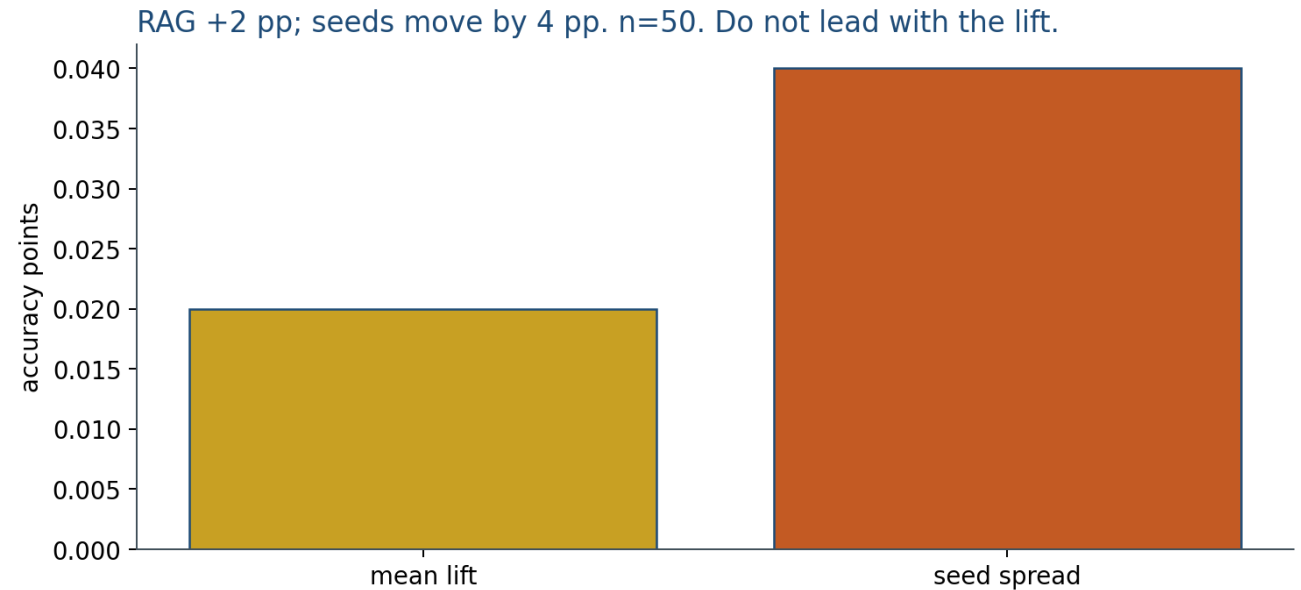
- Name the knob, the split, and n.
- A demo GIF is not a substitute for a number.
- If a closed API is in the loop, still show an open baseline.

A talk is an evaluation story, not a gallery of screenshots



Do not lead with a 2-point bump

- RAG 0.82 and 0.78 (mean 0.80).
Baseline 0.80 and 0.76 (mean 0.78).
- Lift 0.02. Seed spread 0.04. n=50.
- Say that out loud. Then show a failure
RAG actually changed.



Ablation vs theater

Fake ablation

You claimed LoRA; you turned off dropout. That was not the claim.

Real ablation

Turn off the claimed knob (no retrieval, $k=1$, no CoT) and show the metric move.

If one minute remains

Drop this

A second architecture diagram the back row cannot read.

Keep this

The failure: query, retrieved ids, what broke.

What to take from this lecture

Spine

30 s question, 1 min picture, 1 min table, 1 min failure.

Canvas

Slot and upload are official. Week 15 leftover talks too.

Peyton Jones

Start with the problem. Mechanism later.